

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

Decades ago when George Fernandes gave up the cassock and quit the seminary for a baptism in socialism, he was branded a rebel. That hardly deterred him. Not much has changed about this eternal rebel even now, as George Fernandes still has the same spark in his eyes plus the courage and conviction to swim against the tide. The only thing missing is perhaps the thing that matters most—his fiery speech and quick reflexes. His body seems incapable to translate his thoughts into action.

George has reportedly undergone a brain operation, which has slowed him. But the patriarch is unperturbed. "I don't care what they (Nitish Kumar and Sharad Yadav) think. I am here to win. They have become autocrats," George told *INDIA TODAY*, sitting cosy in his Muzaffarpur hotel room. The voice drones on, his words shorn of any emotions, as if the man was reporting a statistic. But betraying little or zero emotions serves a purpose. Perhaps he wants to convey that the opposition is immaterial to him. The blankness in his eyes convinces one of his resolve.

George is now contesting the Lok Sabha elections from Muzaffarpur in Bihar, the constituency he represented in the 14th Lok Sabha. This time, he is contesting as a Janata Dal (United) rebel after Nitish Kumar and Sharad Yadav refused him a ticket, explaining that his "poor health" will not allow him to withstand the rigours of contesting an election. A defiant George, however, has rejected these arguments. "I'm old but I'm okay. And socialists don't go to the Rajya Sabha."

Not for nothing is he participating in the road shows while sitting on the front seat of a red Mahindra Xylo—the colour of rebellion. Veteran and veritable George has won many battles in his combative political career. But today, in 2009, all of 42 years after he was first elected to the Lok Sabha—when this protagonist of the proletariat is taking probably one last shot at electoral politics, he has a mountain to climb. Many of his supporters like MLA Manoj



The Dragon SLAYER

Let down by his own prodigy, George Fernandes rebels again as he sets out to fight for the Muzaffarpur seat

Kushwaha have deserted him, perhaps to stay in the good books of the JD(U) bosses. Many friendships, however, are still intact, while a few are still joining him midway.

Understandably, many people in Muzaffarpur have a soft corner for the

man who they elected first in 1977, when he was still in prison and who had gone to file his nomination in handcuffs. George, a Christian from Karnataka, was a very unlikely leader in caste-ridden Bihar. Even now he is perhaps one of the few whose appeal